Merit Badges

FACT SHEET

Background

Scouts can earn more than 100 merit badges, including the newest merit badges—Welding, Chess, and Robotics. Earning merit badges gives Scouts the opportunity to participate in activities and study subjects that prepare them for life. For information on merit badge requirements and resources, go to the following link: http://www.scouting.org/scoutsource/BoyScouts/AdvancementandAwards/MeritBadges.aspx

Merit Badge Popularity

The top 10 merit badges required for Eagle rank earned in 2011:

- First Aid
- Swimming
- Environmental Science
- Citizenship in the World
- Citizenship in the Nation
- Camping
- Communications
- Citizenship in the Community
- Personal Fitness
- Family Life

The top 10 merit badges not required for Eagle rank earned in 2011:

- Rifle Shooting
- Fingerprinting
- Leatherwork
- Wilderness Survival
- Wood Carving
- Archery
- Canoeing
- Art
- Fishing
- Mammal Study

The table below compares merit badge popularity for the past three years by merit badge name. This table also includes the overall count for each merit badge. To date, Scouts have earned more than 113 million merit badges.

Merit Badge	2009	2010	2011	Overall
American Business	685	667	707	51,006
American Cultures	2,710	2,353	2,965	60,063
American Heritage	5,625	5,853	6,645	140,667
American Labor	822	739	1,168	19,915
Animal Science	3,444	3,591	3,759	48,358

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Merit Badge	2009	2010	2011	Overall
Archaeology	7,821	7,939	9,586	128,109
Archery	46,579	45,039	45,204	1,468,498
Architecture	2,691	2,840	3,586	204,839
Art	31,034	28,707	32,146	1,226,068
Astronomy	10,384	10,048	14,941	589,856
Athletics	3,779	3,728	3,411	1,054,590
Automotive Maintenance	9,181	9,520	10,762	136,454
Aviation	20,787	21,173	21,440	547,894
Backpacking	5,003	4,377	4,445	201,115
Basketry	27,179	23,899	23,505	2,380,907
Bird Study	6,268	6,668	6,881	563,187
Bugling	662	844	628	168,340
Camping*	62,774	62,174	62,492	4,488,693
Canoeing	41,918	40,160	41,601	2,919,350
Chemistry	8,248	8,661	9,569	319,446
Chess	0	0	6,002	6,002
Cinematography	6,819	6,529	7,245	83,316
Citizenship in the Community*	59,203	58,891	57,785	3,295,149
Citizenship in the Nation*	64,847	64,683	64,558	3,022,855
Citizenship in the World*	68,075	67,483	67,779	2,075,518
Climbing	25,192	23,698	24,617	345,840
Coin Collecting	7,023	6,785	7,052	480,131
Collections	5,614	6,090	5,027	127,520
Communications*	62,153	59,462	60,749	1,885,591
Composite Materials	1,380	1,603	1,817	8,204
Computers	15,166	14,474	14,712	476,212
Cooking	24,496	23,548	23,989	4,170,166
Crime Prevention	6,981	8,049	8,374	114,146
Cycling**	7,736	7,533	6,992	555,306

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Dentistry	5,231	5,506	4,491	123,352
Disabilities Awareness	6,100	7,362	7,503	101,352
Dog Care	3,373	3,455	3,407	421,826
Drafting	1,514	1,516	1,170	220,523
Electricity	11,585	10,419	11,187	772,027
Electronics	7,112	7,452	7,186	190,832
Emergency Preparedness***	50,707	49,945	50,510	1,690,072
Energy	3,427	3,203	3,641	68,828
Engineering	7,361	9,459	9,418	114,785
Entrepreneurship	1,609	1,582	1,895	16,114
Environmental Science*	77,285	74,836	78,719	2,497,522
Family Life*	58,568	58,767	55,812	999,539
Farm Mechanics	2,625	2,387	2,627	213,438
Fingerprinting	46,808	46,395	53,189	1,538,844
Fire Safety	17,784	15,483	16,886	2,567,752
First Aid*	91,334	89,694	94,268	6,721,194
Fish and Wildlife Management	16,971	14,825	16,162	610,520
Fishing	28,692	29,806	32,048	1,899,110
Fly Fishing	634	475	4,605	13,661
Forestry	16,843	14,906	16,456	1,105,297
Gardening	2,576	2,403	2,422	381,642
Genealogy	5,674	6,386	5,452	214,783
Geocaching	0	4,533	19,419	23,952
Geology	23,640	21,798	23,695	579,722
Golf	7,623	7,236	5,798	152,766
Graphic Arts	2,982	3,093	3,620	41,109
Hiking**	8,074	7,658	7,946	1,306,885
Home Repairs	5,165	4,572	4,324	2,403,101
Horsemanship	13,106	13,230	13,814	606,167

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Indian Lore	31,293	28,530	28,591	1,123,631
Insect Study	2,582	3,502	3,579	154,186
Inventing	0	616	2,279	2,895
Journalism	1,285	1,191	1,285	103,298
Landscape Architecture	1,335	1,414	1,475	76,725
Law	7,044	7,333	7,315	165,082
Leatherwork	53,896	50,028	51,535	2,311,496
Lifesaving***	28,483	27,739	29,382	2,958,761
Mammal Study	31,245	28,728	31,028	1,118,915
Medicine	4,513	4,547	4,480	60,326
Metalwork	12,272	11,597	12,790	1,094,757
Model Design and Building	2,586	2,123	2,964	210,816
Motor Boating	12,985	12,578	12,133	552,574
Music	17,565	16,623	15,875	1,276,543
Nature	18,404	16,773	18,453	1,616,118
Nuclear Science	5,881	5,908	6,965	152,299
Oceanography	10,202	11,098	10,720	256,950
Orienteering	20,723	18,328	20,221	764,372
Painting	4,696	4,217	5,087	547,455
Personal Fitness*	58,461	58,988	56,588	2,335,331
Personal Management*	56,330	56,793	53,459	1,655,885
Pets	6,900	6,346	6,068	642,279
Photography	17,543	17,479	18,042	451,026
Pioneering	22,596	21,008	23,138	2,354,016
Plant Science	1,779	1,797	2,614	36,816
Plumbing	7,055	6,233	6,417	375,433
Pottery	9,885	8,937	10,493	354,875
Public Health	1,928	1,958	1,989	1,512,035
Public Speaking	6,940	6,671	6,703	621,136

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Pulp and Paper	4,933	5,549	6,449	93,828
Radio	7,190	6,994	6,257	151,652
Railroading	7,484	8,868	9,144	214,789
Reading	7,183	6,590	5,889	1,467,440
Reptile and Amphibian Study	9,902	9,797	9,816	622,300
Rifle Shooting	51,562	50,801	54,276	1,184,651
Robotics	0	0	5,407	5,407
Rowing	16,878	14,948	15,906	1,682,568
Safety	4,304	4,088	4,128	2,923,063
Salesmanship	5,704	6,286	6,765	305,319
Scholarship	7,194	7,034	6,570	1,259,086
Scouting Heritage	0	3,814	6,407	10,221
Scuba Diving	130	2,962	3,015	6,107
Sculpture	10,372	10,750	13,074	268,199
Shotgun Shooting	25,086	24,978	27,838	445,534
Skating	3,360	3,119	3,208	166,724
Small Boat Sailing	19,145	18,471	19,895	600,201
Snow Sports	11,326	11,394	10,586	425,221
Soil and Water Conservation	15,546	15,298	15,554	1,084,699
Space Exploration	21,977	22,914	23,595	490,399
Sports	10,444	9,550	9,167	1,119,295
Stamp Collecting	1,087	1,434	1,147	386,468
Surveying	1,595	1,539	1,145	148,041
Swimming**	76,807	78,825	80,938	6,088,942
Textile	2,641	2,232	3,657	129,962
Theater	2,290	2,174	2,201	76,293
Traffic Safety	7,745	7,148	8,665	135,451
Truck Transportation	3,291	2,960	3,009	129,620
Veterinary Medicine	3,018	3,855	3,502	66,295

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Water Sports	5,135	4,891	4,783	238,234
Weather	17,927	16,345	18,582	528,285
Whitewater	3,993	3,372	4,322	77,486
Wilderness Survival	44,632	41,627	46,757	1,504,946
Wood Carving	48,489	45,121	45,645	2,162,862
Woodwork	5,217	5,866	5,590	956,164
TOTAL	**2,096,676**	**2,056,867**	**2,164,366**	**113,001,809**

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New Merit Badges—Youth Interest Survey

The Research & Program Innovation Department surveys Boy Scouts and parents of Boy Scouts to gather interest and feedback on upcoming merit badges. Feedback from previous Youth Interest surveys has been used in development of the following merit badges: Geocaching, Inventing, Robotics, Chess, and Welding. Youth Interest surveys are sent to current Scouting Youth Panel and Parents of Boy Scout Panel members. To join the Scouting Youth Panel or the Parents of Boy Scouts Panel, go to: http://scouting.org/about/research/ResearchPanel.aspx.

The panel entry links are on the center of the page.